TRUMP MANAGEMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

TRUMP MANAGEMENT LESSON

When you play a suit contract the first, and usually most important, decision you need to make is whether to start by pulling trumps. Fortunately there is a rule for you to follow which is never wrong.

YOU SHOULD ALWAYS PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY -
EXCEPT FOR THOSE TIMES WHEN YOU SHOULDN'T

This lesson and the Deals that go with it will show you those times.

Always pull trumps immediately:

The contract is 4♥ and West leads the ♠J.

♠ 7 3
♥ A J 9 4 2
♦ 9 6 4
♣ Q J 10



♠ A K Q
♥ K Q 10 5 3
♦ 8 7 3
♣ K 3

You have 3 losers in ♦s and 1 in ♣s.

You are ecstatic that West didn't lead a minor suit so you play your 3 high ♠s and discard a ♦ from dummy on the third one. Unfortunately East ruffs the ♠ and the defense takes their **2** ♦ tricks plus the ♣A.

This is a really basic example but I'll bet we have all seen it happen. Of course you should win the first trick, **THEN PULL TRUMPS**, then run the ♠s for the discard.

Too easy you say, and you are right. Probably everybody reading this would have pulled trumps.

Have you ever had someone, (your partner?), tell you that they couldn't pull trumps because the suit was too weak? Bad reasoning; with weak trumps and strong side suits you should lead trumps early and often.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♣8.

♠ 7 4 3 2
♥ A K Q
♦ J 10 9
♣ K J 9



♠ 9 8 6 5
♥ J 10 9
♦ A K Q
♣ A Q 10

You have no losers in any suit except trumps.

And if the trumps split 3-2 you can HOPE to lose only 3 tricks there. So you should win the first trick and lead a trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and play another trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and lose one more trump if you like, it doesn't matter at this point.

But think what could happen if you didn't play on trumps at every opportunity. You could be leading high side suit cards and East ruffs a ♣ with the ♠10. Then West ruffs a ♥ with the ♠J. And East ruffs with the ♠Q, and West ruffs with the ♠K and somebody still has the ♠A. In other words the defenders had 5 high trumps and you let them make them all individually.

Point made.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need to ruff tricks in dummy:

The contract is 6♦ and West leads the ♦5.

♠ 8 5
♥ 9 6 5 2
♦ 7 4
♣ A K 7 4 2



♠ A K 4 3
♥ A K 3
♦ A K Q J 9
♣ 5

You have 2 losers in ♠s and 1 in ♥s.
You can pull trumps, then discard the ♥ loser on dummy's high ♣, but you will still be left with the 2 ♠s.

A better play is delay pulling trumps. Play the ♠ A K 4, ruffing the ♠4 with dummy's last trump. Then play a ♥ to your hand and now pull trumps.

You will still have 1 ♠ loser at the end but you will make the contract.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you need the trump suit for entries:

The contract is 6♠ and West leads the ♣K.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ 7 3 2
♣ 8 5 4 2



♠ A J 10 9 6 4
♥ A K
♦ A Q J
♣ A 7

With a sure ♣ loser you need to have the ♦ finesse.

Suppose trumps split 3-1 (probable) and you pull them ending in dummy. You can then take the ♦ finesse but even when it wins you are doomed because you cannot repeat it.

Instead win the first trick and play ♠A then small to dummy's ♠Q. Now finesse the ♦ successfully and return to the ♠K, pulling the last trump. Finesse the ♦ once more and claim.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you can't afford to lose the lead yet:

Perhaps the reason you can't afford to lose the lead yet is that you need to discard a loser quickly. The contract is 5♣ and West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ A 8
♣ Q 6 5 4 3



♠ A 4
♥ A 7 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ K J 9 8 7

The ♥ lead has exposed your 2 ♥ losers early.

You can ruff the small ♦ in dummy, but you cannot avoid losing the Ace of trumps. If you lead a ♣ now the defenders will grab their ♣A and immediately cash their 2 ♥ tricks.

So before playing a trump you play 3 ♠s, discarding a ♥ on dummy's third ♠. Only then is it safe to start pulling trumps.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan to play a cross-ruff:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♦K.

♠ A
♥ Q J 9 7
♦ 9 8 7 5 3
♣ A 7 5



♠ 9 8 7 4 2
♥ A K 10 8
♦ A
♣ K 6 4

You can win your 4 side suit high cards, then alternate ruffing 4 ♠s in dummy and 4 ♦s in your hand.

One of the two keys to a cross-ruff is that you might not have enough winners if you play a round of trumps. In this deal, for example, you needed to make all 8 trumps individually; even one lead would have cost you two trumps for one winning trick.

The second key is that you must take any side-suit winners early. Here if you delay taking your ♣A and ♣K, one of the defenders might discard ♣s while you are playing the other suits and be able to ruff a ♣ winner late in the game.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . you plan a dummy reversal:

A mistake made frequently by beginners is taking an early ruff in the long-trump hand. When you ruff in the short-trump hand it does two good things - it gives you an immediate winner and it also gives you an extra winner. When you ruff in the long-trump hand it gives you an immediate winner but it seldom gives you an extra trick.

Look at these three hands:

You are playing a ♥ contract and West leads the ♣ A K.

♠ K J 7 2
♥ K Q J
♦ 6 5 4 3 2
♣ 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ --
♣ 5 4 3

You can ruff 2 ♣s in dummy, the short-trump hand.

You will now make a total of 7 trump tricks, your 5 plus dummy's 2 ruffs.

Dummy's ruffs have actually gained you 2 tricks.

♠ K J 7
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

You can ruff the second ♣ in your hand, the long-trump hand.

You could even ruff dummy's last ♣ if you wanted to, but it wouldn't help you.

Because ruffing in your hand hasn't gained you any tricks, you still only get 5 trump tricks.

♠ K J
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 4 2



♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

Ruff the second ♣ in your hand with the ♥A.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J.
Ruff dummy's third ♣ in your hand.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q.
Ruff dummy's last ♣ with your last ♥.
Play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K.
Pull the opponents' last trump with dummy's ♥K, discarding your ♦ loser.
Overtake dummy's ♠J and your hand is good.
You actually made 6 trump tricks, 3 ruffs in your hand, and the 3 you pulled trumps with in dummy.

This is called a Dummy Reversal - because you used dummy's hand to pull trumps with, and took the ruffs in your own hand.

Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .
. . . the only trump left out is the master trump:

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 2
♥ K 5 4
♦ A 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A Q 7 6 2
♦ K 9 8 4 2
♣ 4 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥K, then the ♥A. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥ play so you will lose a trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

You continue with the ♥Q which leaves you with just the ♥7 remaining in your hand while East has the master ♥J. Should you play the final trump?

Heck no! If you did there would be no stopping the avalanche of ♠s they would play! Instead, just start running dummy's ♣s until East gets frustrated and ruffs with the ♥J. Of course that now leaves you with a trump to stop the ♠s.

Despite the above suggestion, there is a time when you do not want to leave the master trump left out - when dummy has a long suit to run but has no outside entries. Change the previous hand around.

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 3 2
♥ 5 4
♦ 4 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9



♠ --
♥ A K Q 7 6 2
♦ A 9 8 4 2
♣ 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥A, then the ♥K. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥, so you will lose a trump trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

Suppose you pull just one more trump with the ♥Q, then switch to ♣s, leaving East with the master ♥J. No good. East will ruff the second or third ♣ and even though you will have trump control you won't have a way back to dummy's good ♣s.

Instead you go ahead and force Easts ♥J out with your ♥7, still leaving you with the ♥6. If East plays a ♠ you can ruff with the last trump and then run the ♣ suit uninterrupted.

The last word:

This lesson and the practice Deals are mainly about the various times when you need to delay pulling trumps or perhaps not pull them at all. Don't let that give you the wrong idea though.

MOST OF THE TIME YOU SHOULD PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY

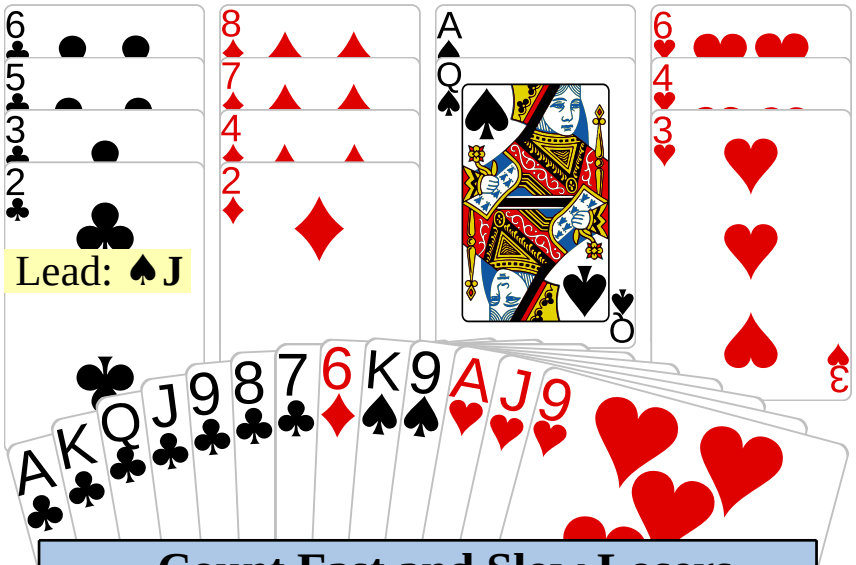
. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



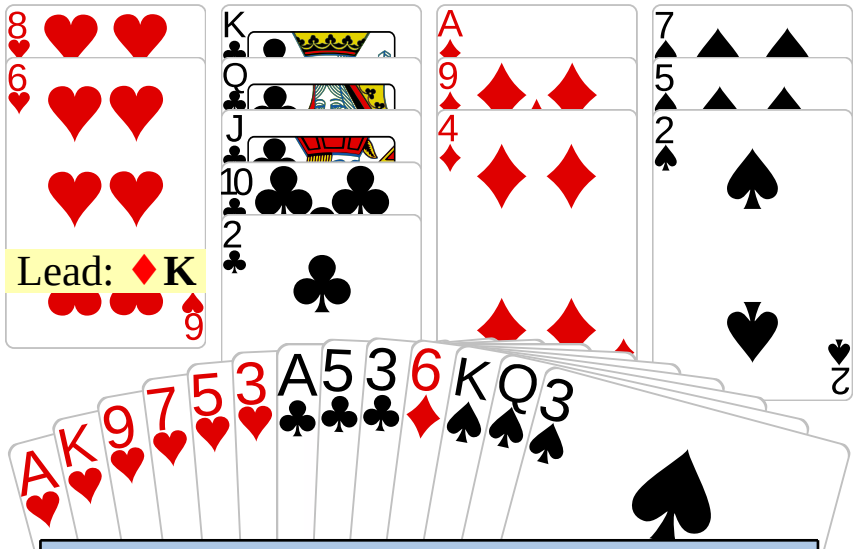
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **5♣** Goal: at most ____ losers



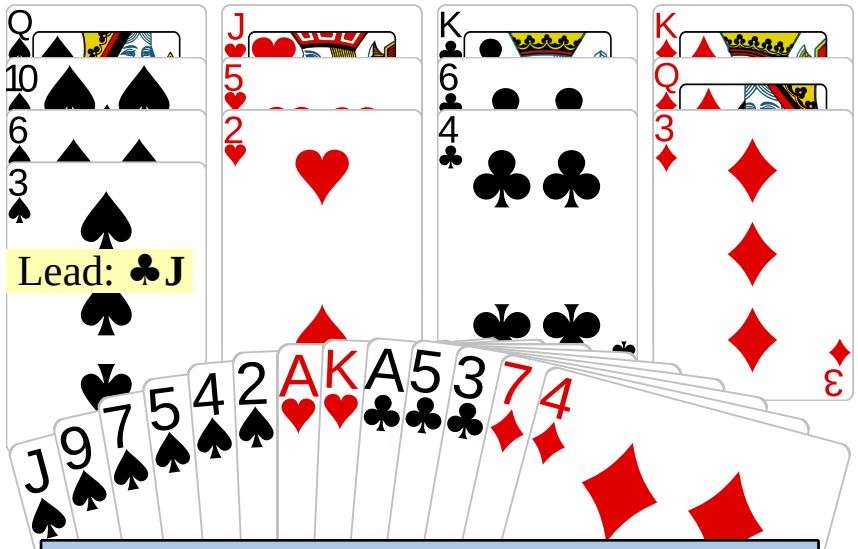
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



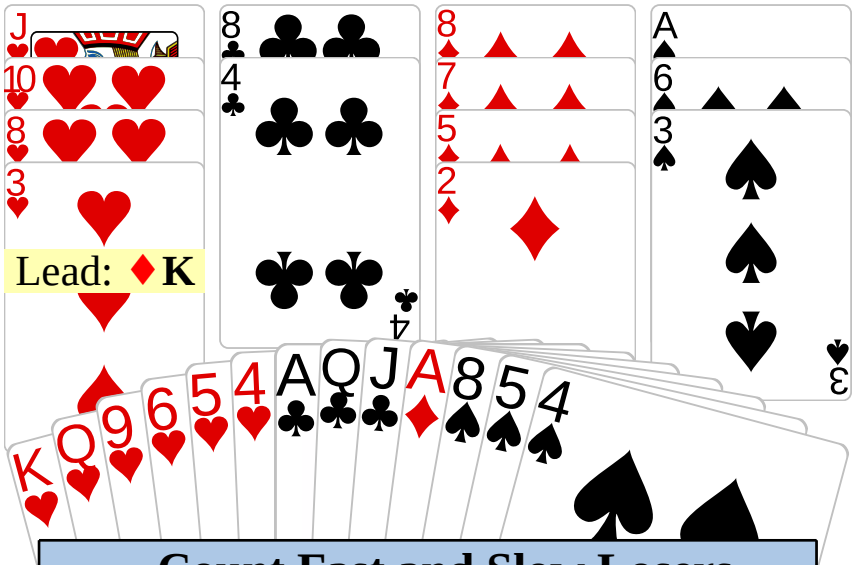
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 5♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K Q 9 5 3
♥ A
♦ A K 4
♣ A K 2

♠ J 7 6 2
♥ 10 7 4 3
♦ 9 5
♣ Q J 6



♠ 4
♥ J 9 5 2
♦ Q J 10 6 3
♣ 10 8 4

♠ 10 8
♥ K Q 8 6
♦ 8 7 2
♣ 9 7 5 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♥
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

6♠ by North
Lead: ♦Q

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♦Q.

Losers: ♠ = 0 or 1 ♥ = 0 ♦ = 1 ♣ = 1 Total = 2 or 3

You probably do not have a trump loser because they will probably split 3-2. Still, a 4-1 split is certainly not out of the question.

But those two minor suit losers are definite **UNLESS** you can somehow get to dummy's ♥ K Q. Can you?

You win the ♦A.

Everyone follows.

West wins the ♠J.

Yes you can get to dummy, in the trump suit. Win the opening ♦ lead. Unblock the ♥A before touching trumps. Play a **SMALL** trump toward dummy. A defender will surely take his ♠J here, and play another ♦. Win that trick and play another small ♠. This one will get you into dummy. And by the way, East discards a ♦ so it turns out you were going to lose a trump in any case. Play dummy's ♥ K Q, discarding your two minor losers. Ruff a ♥ to return to your hand, pull trumps and claim.

As you can see you have a trump loser in addition to the small ♦ and ♣. By establishing the ♠ entry to dummy you can discard the ♦ and ♣.

You can see how it works if the trump suit DID split 3-2 as you would expect it to do. Even without a trump loser you will still go down 1 if you cannot take two discards on dummy's ♥s.

So you give up a trump trick and gain two ♥ tricks in return. What a deal.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 7 5 4 2 ♥ K 10 5 2 ♦ K J 9 3 ♣ 10	
♠ A Q ♥ 6 4 3 ♦ 8 7 4 2 ♣ 6 5 3 2	N W E S	♠ K 9 ♥ A J 9 ♦ 6 ♣ A K Q J 9 8 7
	♠ J 10 8 6 3 ♥ Q 8 7 ♦ A Q 10 5 ♣ 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♣	Pass
1NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
4♣	Pass	5♣	
All Pass			

5♣ by East
Lead: ♠J

East is to play 5♣. South leads the ♠J; dummy wins with the ♠Q, North plays the ♠2 and you the ♠9.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 3

You have no way to get rid of the Fast ♦ loser, but you might be able to eliminate one of the ♥ losers. If North holds either ♥ K 10 x or ♥ Q 10 x then a Deep Finesse would save one loser.

Should you pull trumps right away?

North plays low.

No, you cannot pull trumps yet. For the Deep Finesse to work you must lead twice from dummy. The only way to get into dummy twice is in the ♠ suit and one of those times must be at trick 1.

Win the first trick with dummy's ♠Q and play a ♥ to your ♥9. Assume South wins with the ♥K or ♥Q, and plays another ♠.

In dummy for the last time, play a ♥ to your ♥J and hope it wins.

As you can see, you must play ♥s twice from dummy in order to take the two finesses.

So you couldn't pull that one round of trumps because you couldn't waste either visit to dummy for anything other than the ♥ finesses.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 5 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ A 9 4 ♣ K Q J 10 2	
♠ A 9 8 4 ♥ 4 ♦ K Q 8 7 3 ♣ 9 8 6	N W E S	♠ J 10 6 ♥ Q J 10 2 ♦ J 10 5 2 ♣ 7 4
	♠ K Q 3 ♥ A K 9 7 5 3 ♦ 6 ♣ A 5 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	2♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦K

South is to play 4♥. West leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠ = 2 ♥ = 1 or 2 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 or 4

In fact if trumps split 5-0 you could have 3 losers in the suit and a disaster. So we won't worry about that possibility. Since the most likely scenario is a 3-2 split you should plan on taking the ♥ A K, then driving out their master trump so you can run dummy's ♣s without somebody ruffing in.

Bad news. West discards a ♦ on the second ♥ lead. Time for a change in plans?

No change of plan is needed. East has 2 master trumps at this point but you still have ♥ 9 7 5 3. So use one of your little ones to drive out East's ♥J. He will probably force you to ruff a ♦, leaving you with ♥ 9 7. Use one of them to force out East's ♥Q. You still have a trump left to stop their ♦s, and as soon as you get the lead you can now run dummy's ♣ suit safely.

Suppose you had not driven out both of East's high trumps.

He would have ruffed the third ♣, before you could discard a ♠ loser from your hand. You would lose two trumps and two ♠s.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 8 ♥ 8 7 6 3 ♦ A 9 6 5 ♣ J 10 9 8	
♠ J 9 7 5 4 2 ♥ A K ♦ 7 4 ♣ A 5 3	N W E S	♠ Q 10 6 3 ♥ J 5 2 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ K 6 4
	♠ A K ♥ Q 10 9 4 ♦ J 10 8 2 ♣ Q 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♠	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♣J

West is to play 4♠. North leads the ♣J.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

Unless the defense slips you are going to lose the Ace and King of trumps. And the ♦A is a Fast loser that they can take whenever they want to, so that means you must try to dispose of your ♣ loser. The only realistic hope is that North holds the ♦A and you can lead through it twice. So after you win your ♣A do you play a trump?

North plays low.

Dummy's ♦ honour holds the trick.

South plays low.

You are back in your hand.

North takes his ♦A.

As much as you'd like to get the trumps out you must work on the ♦s first. Because if you play even one trump the defense will win it and force out your remaining ♣ stopper before you have established a ♦ winner for the discard.

The correct procedure is to win the ♣A, and immediately play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q, which holds the trick. Return to your hand with a ♥, and play another ♦ toward dummy. Suppose North takes his ♦A on this trick (otherwise you have no ♦ loser). He can now play a ♣ but you win with dummy's ♣K and discard your small ♣ on dummy's ♦K.

Only then do you lead trumps.

This is the perfect example of when you delay leading trumps.

When you need to do something else first - in this case, to establish a ♦s winner early.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 ♥ A K J 6 3 ♦ A 8 3 2 ♣ 7 6 2	
♠ J 8 4 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ J 10 5 4 ♣ K Q 10	N W E S	♠ K Q 9 6 3 ♥ 8 5 ♦ 9 6 ♣ A J 9 3
	♠ A 7 5 2 ♥ Q 10 9 ♦ K Q 7 ♣ 8 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♦	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠K

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♠K, taken by dummy's ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 4

One possibility is to pull trumps and play for a 3-3 ♦ split. This will occur about 36% of the time. While you may not know all the bridge probabilities, it is useful to remember that an EVEN number of cards (6 in this case) will probably NOT split EVENLY (3-3 in this case). So, let's try to improve on 36%.

You could play to pull just two rounds of trumps, then ruff your fourth ♦, hoping that the defender with the third trump also has the fourth ♦. These odds are tougher to figure, but it doesn't look good, does it?

If you don't see a better Plan than these two, just put yourself in Dummy's seat and pretend you are playing 4♥ from that side of the table.

Dummy leads a ♠ and West plays low.

Aha! From dummy's viewpoint you have no ♦ losers! You still have the 3 ♣ losers, but now you also have 3 ♠ losers. How does this help you?

You can now ruff all 3 of those ♠ losers in the North hand. Like this:Win the ♠A and ruff a ♠ with the ♥A. Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥9. Ruff another ♠ with the ♥K. Play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥10. Ruff dummy's last ♠ with your last trump, the ♥J. Enter dummy with a ♦ and pull the last trump with the ♥Q.

You win 3 ♦s, 3 ♥s in dummy, the ♠A and 3 ♠ ruffs in your hand. Total: 10 tricks.

This is a Dummy Reversal. You take some ruffs in the long-trump hand, and pull trumps with the short-trump hand.

For a Dummy Reversal to work you usually have to have a decent trump split.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K Q J 2 ♥ A ♦ 10 6 4 3 ♣ 10 7 5 2	
♠ A 6 3 ♥ J 10 8 3 ♦ 8 7 5 2 ♣ 8 4		♠ 8 5 4 ♥ K Q 9 6 5 4 ♦ A ♣ A Q J
	♠ 10 9 7 ♥ 7 2 ♦ K Q J 9 ♣ K 9 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	Pass
2♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♦K

East is to play 4♥. South leads the ♦K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

You could go to dummy with the ♠A and try a finesse for the ♣K. If it works, no more ♣ loser. But if it fails the bad guys will cash a couple of ♠s and even you can't dodge the Ace of trumps.

Or, you could try to get to dummy with a trump to the ♥J so you could make the ♣ finesse while dummy still keeps the ♠A. Of course the defenders would probably take the first ♥ and then knock out your ♠A. When the ♣ finesse failed, same bad result. What else might you try?

You win the ♦A.

Forget the ♣ finesse. Forget pulling trumps. Win the first trick and play any ♣ from your hand. Let's say you play the ♣J. A defender wins the ♣K and attacks ♠s. Too late, you are in the driver's seat. Win the ♠A, play a ♣ to your ♣Q, and then play the ♣A, discarding a ♠ from dummy. You lose the Ace of trumps, one ♣, and just one ♠.

Leading a ♠ to dummy for a ♣ finesse might have worked.

Trying to sneak into dummy with a trump might have worked.

Playing a ♣ from your hand at the second trick **WILL** work.